

Metaphysics

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What is metaphysics?

- Etymology: Aristotle wrote a treatise which was called ‘the book that came after the Physics’ because of its place in the sequence.
- History: “spinning off” of other fields of philosophy (e.g. philosophy of mind) from metaphysics.

- Metaphysics is concerned with questions about the *ultimate nature of reality*.
 - Insofar as these questions can be answered from the armchair.
 - Can they ever be?
 - What experiment would you have us do to decide whether God exists, or whether there are material objects?

Our focus: *ontology*

- Old definition: ‘science of being *qua* being’
- Quine’s definition: concerned with the question ‘What is there?’
 - To be more precise: questions of the form ‘Are there any Fs?’, where ‘F’ is some very general term.

- Are there *really* any...
 - ...material objects?
 - ...statues, lumps of clay, arms and legs, and other such things?
 - ...large (composite) objects at all?
 - ...numbers?
 - ...properties or universals?
 - ...particular individual things, or objects?
- ...and if so, what are these things like, and how are they related to things of other sorts?

- One distinguishing feature of these questions: there's a way of hearing them on which the answer is 'obviously yes'.
- But this may be a 'loose', philosophically misleading way of talking. Maybe we can explain how 'there is a hole in this piece of cheese' gets to be true in the loose sense without having to accept that there really are these strange things, holes.

Other kinds of metaphysical questions

- Very general ‘why’ questions, like ‘why is there something rather than nothing’.
 - We won’t be talking about these at all.

- Very general ‘what is it’ questions, which aren’t clearly to be answered by any of the sciences or by other branches of philosophy. EG:
 - What is it for something to be *possible* / *necessary*?
 - What is it for something to *cause* something else?
 - What is it for someone to have *free will*?
 - What is it for something to *change*?
 - What is it for two things to *resemble* one another?
- We will consider quite a few of these questions – for example, the last two of the above.

Doubts about the worthwhileness of metaphysics

- “This question is too hard: we could never know what the answer is.”
- “This question is meaningless, so it doesn’t have an answer.”
- “This question is ambiguous. In one sense, the answer is ‘yes’; in another, the answer is ‘no’.”
- “The answer to this question is simply obvious.”
- “This question belongs to science, not philosophy”